

What Is The Mark Of A Good Church?

My initial response to this question would be to quote one of our most familiar creedal sayings and apply this to the church. The first question of the *Westminster Shorter Catechism*, asks, “What is the chief end of man?” Answer?

Man’s chief end is to glorify God, and to enjoy Him forever!

Without a doubt, from the vantage point of the Bible, the mark of a good church is that she both “glorifies God” among the nations while also enabling the people to “enjoy” Him, both in this life and in the life to come! I think of the doxological benediction at the conclusion of the epistle to Jude, wherein the *telos* of everything said and done in the church is summarized:

*Now to him who is able to keep you from falling, and to make you stand without blemish in the presence of his glory with rejoicing, to the only God our Savior, through Jesus Christ our Lord, be glory, majesty, power, and authority, before all time and now and forever.
Amen.*

Even God’s actions unto human salvation are subordinated to this great aim, to glorify His Holy Name among the nations!

Therefore say to the house of Israel, Thus says the Lord GOD: It is not for your sake, O house of Israel, that I am about to act, but for the sake of my holy name

Ezek. 36:22

But how does this result in our “enjoying God forever?” And related to this, why not just leave well enough alone, and say therefore that the chief mark of a good Church is to glorify God and enjoy him forever? Well, because if left alone, this statement could be tragically misleading! This statement might suggest that the people of any given church are all about being holy, righteous, loving, merciful and whatever else it would mean to glorify God in order then to enjoy God forever. But if the truth be known, no church really does this. It would be to posit as the mark of a good church what no church is! And in fact, a good church will confess as much every time she meets together on Sundays. And yet, the church with this as her motto might well focus on being holy, or trying to act like we are holy, in order to act like we glorify God. We would hear a lot of sermons about what we must do to glorify God. We would talk a lot about our attitudes, our behaviors, our words, our worship, our theology, our way of raising children, our music, our... and all with a focus on what we must do to glorify God and enjoy his favor forever!

You see, our focus would be on US, even if under the pretense of “for the glory of God!” So what is a good church all about? It is hopefully about the gospel wherein God IS glorified by faith, not in ourselves and our own human ability to glorify God, but in Christ and His ability to do this for us, or shall we say to complete what we are unable to do! And this changes EVERYTHING!

Hairsplitting? Not hardly! For the above statement in our creed is the first of a long string of subsequent affirmations that in sum will say “God is glorified in the gospel of Jesus Christ! To be sure, it was the ultimate passion of Christ *acting for humanity as the Son of “man”* to glorify God (John 12:28). According to the gospel, “the Son of Man has been glorified, and God has been glorified in him” (John 13:31). Peter proclaims “God is glorified in all things through Jesus Christ” (1Peter 4:11). In sum, we glorify God by faith in Christ, even as this ought to impact our relationships, our message, and everything pertaining even to our church culture!

Consider with me what it would look like if the **gospel** were the focus of a church. More than a message about how to “get in” and “get saved from eternal damnation,” **it would inform the way we relate together--** having been set free from the fear of being condemned, we no longer need to cover up our shortcomings in fear of being rejected. **It changes the way we grow in holiness--** in proportion to the degree that we are experiencing the grace of the gospel vs. in proportion to fearing condemnation by God or one another. Sermons, would talk a lot about Christ’s work of glorifying God, even as this would be applied first to our being right with God, and THEN as a basis for how we can show forth our gratitude in following his example. **It changes the way we think about suffering and weakness--** knowing that God’s power is manifest not in our being made strong, but in our discovering our brokenness in order to proclaim the strength of God on our behalf! All circumstances, however difficult, are viewed as helping us to discover the greater power that works within us, than whatever evil that works in the world. **It changes the way we relate to the world,** in that we will want to be “in the world, FOR THE WORLD, albeit other worldly. This would be in the pattern of Christ who came into the world to “save sinners, not to condemn them! Moreover, knowing the saving grace of the gospel enables us to be more humble about our own sins before the world, while knowing the common grace of God that restrains evil and preserves some good in the world enables us to be less threatened by the gifts that are acting in the world. **It changes the way we relate to our social differences--**the gospel will transcend all racial, cultural and political barriers, since all such barriers are the manifestations of racial, cultural and political pride or inferiority as again related to the fear of condemnation and the need to artificially make ourselves feel better about ourselves by putting others down. On and on it goes... the difference it would make if we could be about the gospel at CPC! In the words of Tim Keller, “the gospel is not just the abc’s, it is also the xyz’s of the Christian life.” (see “Centrality of the Gospel,” by Tim Keller)

Prayer:

God, help me to be transformed by the power of the Gospel. Teach me what it means to experience your radical grace, and then to give it away in all of my relationships. And let this happen so that Christ will be glorified as the one who alone can glorify you. God, glorify yourself as you glorify your Son on behalf of me and live in me more and more!